

CAUSAL MAP GARDEN

For consultants

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FOR CONSULTANTS

CHAPTER CONTENTS.

This chapter explains how individual consultants and agencies can include Causal Map and/or Qualia in their next bid.

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CAUSAL MAPPING – THE EVALUATION EVIDENCE BROKER

Marshalling causal evidence at scale for Contribution Analysis and beyond.

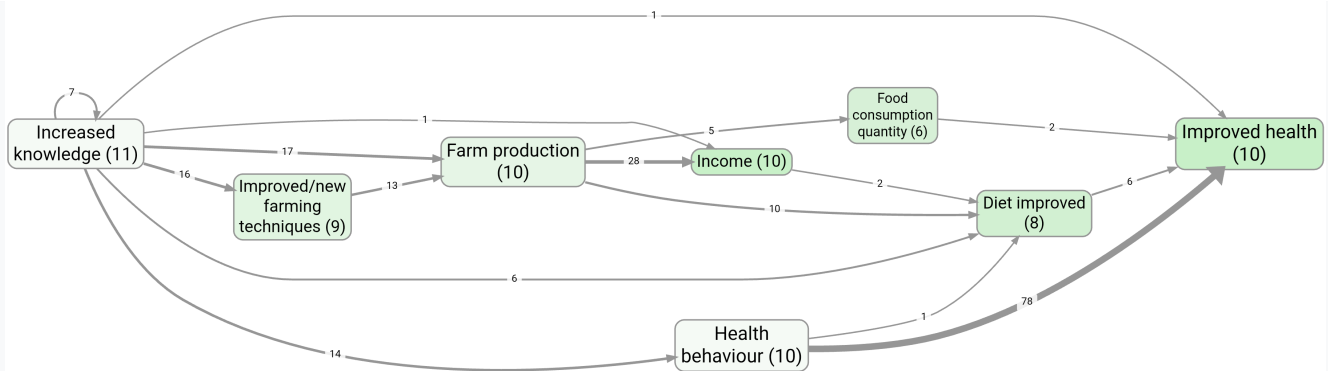
Causal Mapping is not primarily an evaluation method; it is a way of identifying and organising causal claims in support of evaluative judgement.

- It fits naturally with **Contribution Analysis (CA)**, while still adding value to other evidence-based frameworks...
- **Outcome Harvesting:** strengthen contribution claims by identifying the precise causal chain from outcome back to intervention.
- **Realist Evaluation:** identify Context-Mechanism-Outcome (CMO) linkages mentioned by sources.
- **QuIP:** strengthen causal contribution claims through explicit, source-grounded chains.

1 Link = 100 Claims

An arrow in a map can look simple (for example, *Training -> Knowledge*), but that single link can represent dozens or hundreds of auditable claims from different sources.

- It lets evaluators “double-click” on it and examine the different quotes behind each link as well as how often it was mentioned.
- Every claim has verbatim text attached to it.



Scaling analysis with AI

When you move from 10 interviews to 200, manual coding alone is too hard. "Asking ChatGPT" surrenders human judgement to a black box: we don't really know how it reached its conclusions.

Causal Mapping uses AI as a low-level assistant to automate the extraction of traceable causal claims according to strict rules, leaving evaluative judgements to the evaluator.

How causal mapping can help with Contribution Analysis

John Mayne's six Steps, plus one

1 Set out the Attribution Problem

Define the evaluation questions and the level of evidence required.

2 Develop the Theory of Change

Establish the logic of how the intervention is expected to lead to results.

Often there are multiple versions of the "official" theory, or none at all.

Causal mapping helps: Assemble theories of change from official documents.

3

Gather Evidence on the ToC

Collect existing and new evidence to populate the causal links.

Causal mapping helps: Assemble "empirical theories of change" from stakeholder evidence and test if the official theory matches up. There is even a *metric* for that.

4

Assemble the Performance Story

Build the contribution narrative based on synthesised evidence.

Causal mapping helps: Synthesises individual claims into verifiable chains with *path tracing* and *source tracing*.

5

Assess Alternative Explanations

Account for external influences and other drivers of observed change.

Causal mapping helps: Explicitly maps non-project influences mentioned by sources.

6

Revise and Strengthen

Refine the story based on gaps identified in the evidence base.

Causal mapping helps: Highlights weak links where evidence count is low.

7

Extend

Causal mapping helps: A single causal coding of all documents creates a causal database which can provide inputs to all the above steps, and a lot more too.

See how different stakeholder groups view the project differently.

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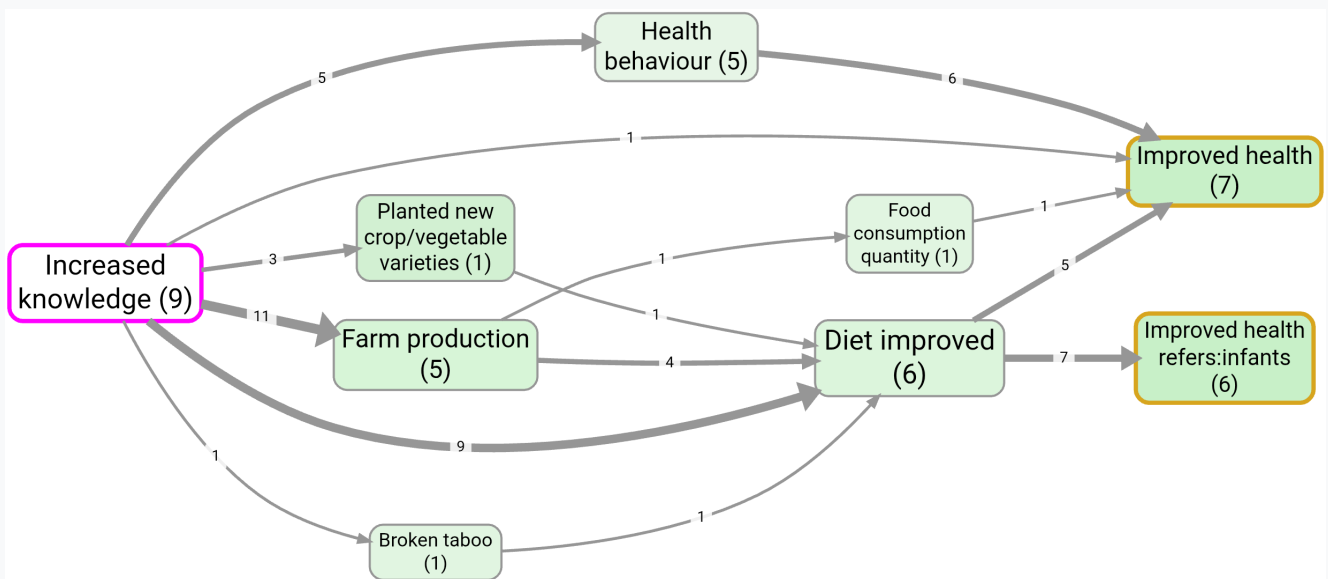
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☐	Factor	Significant	custom_# Age of the main respondent - 20-45	custom_# Age of the main respondent - 46+	# Citations	# Sources	In-Degree	Out-Degree	Outcomes	Avg Incoming Sentiment
		All								
☐	Increased knowledge	No	158	72	230	18	22	208	0.096	0.000
☐	Farm production	Yes	89	68	157	16	76	81	0.484	0.000
☐	Health behaviour	No	93	58	151	17	26	125	0.172	0.000
☐	Improved health	No	89	54	143	17	136	7	0.951	0.000
☐	Diet improved	Yes	78	23	101	18	81	20	0.802	0.000
☐	Income	Yes	44	44	88	15	47	41	0.534	0.000
☐	Planted new crop/vegetabl	No	42	20	62	13	28	34	0.452	0.000
☐	Improved/new farming tec	Yes	20	24	44	14	21	23	0.477	0.000
☐	Ability to buy food	Yes	14	23	37	12	17	20	0.459	0.000
☐	Food consumption quantit	No	22	15	37	17	31	6	0.838	0.000

Visualise pathways.



Provide evidence for individual narratives.

Bundle: Diet improved; Diversified >> Improved health

Source: MNY-5

The meals I buy in the market have changed because I have the option to buy various goods. The spare food type has change as I now have access to better seeds for my farm and some material.

Increased

The motive for this change is in the varieties of foods cultivated in my farm, in my livestock creation and also in the food varieties from the market.

More variety

The reason is as a result of the varieties and the different foods. We have a variety of good in the market. Some from my garden and it is the reason I am healthy.

Source: MSX-1

Increased

MORE FOOD VARIETIES THAT GENERATED A GOOD NUTRITION IN THE FAMILY overall AND WE ALSO CONSERVE MORE FOOD. Increased from the introduction production of horticulture such as tomatoes, onions these enabled more food. With tomatoes and onions we could now do stew to avoid only eating green vegetables.

More variety

AFTER, THE GOOD WAYS OF CONSERVATION OF FOOD AND VARIETIES IN FOODS HELPED A GOOD RESULT IN THE HEALTH OF THE FAMILY.

Why causal mapping ?

Related

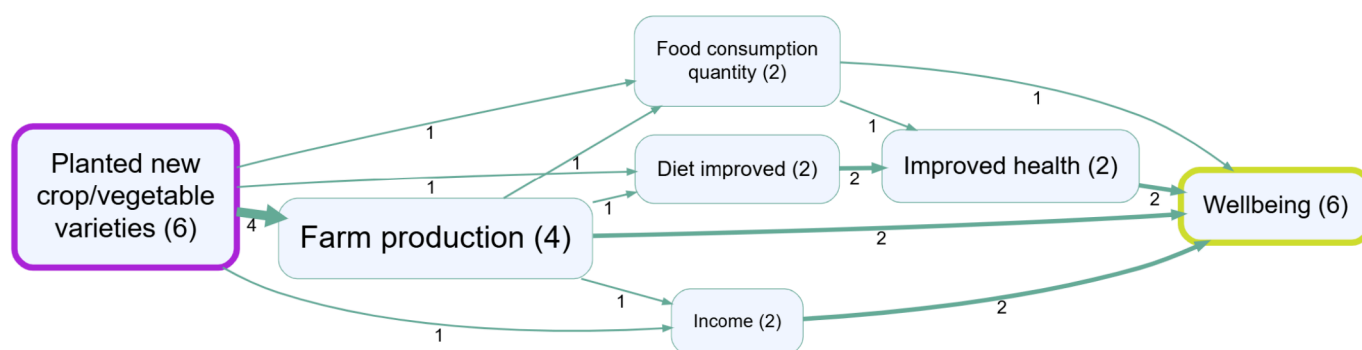
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★ INCLUDE CAUSAL MAP AND QUALIA INTERVIEWS IN YOUR NEXT BID

Preparing a bid? Need to apply a "causal lens"?

Research and evaluation consultancies are increasingly getting asked to "apply a causal lens". Sometimes that's possible with quantitative data. But how to rigorously identify, synthesise and visualise causal narratives within **qualitative data** like interviews and reports?

That is what **causal mapping** is for. At **Causal Map Ltd.**, we can provide that expertise.



Two ways to use causal mapping:

- As a **light overarching framework** for your entire project. Assemble a database of causal evidence from different kinds of sources like interviews and reports. Make sense of it at scale (we can use AI for this, but in a structured and robust and checkable way).
- Just as one part of your project, to **answer specific questions...**

Questions you can answer

- **How does the whole system work**, according to your sources? How is it **changing**? Where are the leverage points?
- What's the evidence that our intervention led to **expected outcomes**, and how?
- What **unexpected outcomes** were there?
- Does the **reality** match the plan?
- Do the young people see this **differently**?

💡 Tip: add **conversational AI-led interviews** to your bid: see the next page.

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★ ADD QUALIA TO YOUR NEXT BID

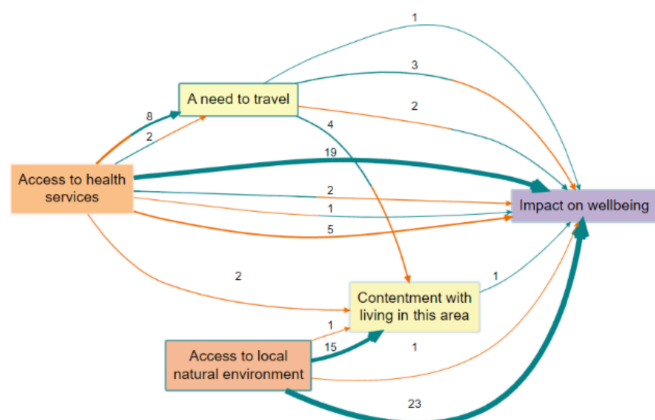
Interviews are **deep but expensive**. **Questionnaires** are **cheap but shallow**.

Qualia is our AI interviewer. Qualia can conduct conversational interviews with any number of respondents, in almost any language.

We find that respondents are on average more candid with Qualia than with a human interviewer. As with any data collection, some respondents drop off right at the start. But we find that once they start talking, they mostly can't stop (!), producing transcripts of multiple pages.

Put Qualia in your next bid:

- Conduct some KIs face-to-face and then get Qualia to follow the same interview guideline but extending your reach to dozens or hundreds of stakeholders.
- Why bother with a traditional questionnaire when you can use Qualia to find out what people are **really** thinking, but at the same scale?



Qualia interviews are very cost-effective. Often, clients engage us for a day or two to help with setting up and monitoring the interview.

You get an automated report. Or download the transcripts for further analysis. Or we can use Causal Map to make sense of the stories at scale.

You can set your Qualia interviews to be **fully GDPR-compliant**: no data leaves the EU, not even for AI processing; no data is stored outside our own EU servers and no data is used to train models.

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BRIEF FOR HR AGENCY MAYBE

Causal Map and Qualia: a back-end for values-driven organisational work

For Gabriele and Fiona first

This is a rough idea: we partner with a consultancy in the HR or organisational development space who already has the clients, the framework and the trust. They do the advising and package it inside some supercool systems/org-development voodoo. We are the engine underneath.

Linking Qualia and/or Causal Map like we did for the British Academy and VIB in Belgium, which worked well. But we are a small, fairly quiet bunch. We are not selling this widely, and we are not the loudest voice on what the analysis should mean. A partner who brings a strong point of view on organisations could carry the front end, while we do what we are good at.

The brief below is something we would adapt for different people. see what you think.

The brief

Where we are

Causal Map Ltd builds two tools for understanding organisations based on what their people actually say. We believe that employee narratives and stories, whether gathered purposefully via targeted interviews or otherwise, are a great insight into hearts and minds, conscious and subconscious, across an organisation.

Qualia is an AI interviewer. It holds a real conversation with each employee or stakeholder, at scale, and gathers their accounts in their own words. Each person follows a link and chats with Qualia in the browser at a time that suits them. Qualia usually asks a few open questions and then probes, following up on whatever the person raises rather than working through a fixed script. Rating scales and predefined answer options are possible but not part of the main process. the output is a set of transcripts in which people explain how they see their work, their team and what causes what.

Causal Map reads those accounts and maps the causal claims inside them: who says what leads to what. Every link traces back to the source text, so nothing is invented and every finding can be checked. If someone says "the new rota means I hardly see my children, so I come in tired and make mistakes", Causal Map codes that as a chain: new rota → less family time → tiredness → mistakes. Coding every interview the same way gives one combined map of the organisation: which beliefs are widespread, which belong to one team only, where the management picture and the shop floor picture diverge. Click any arrow and you see the quotes behind it and who said them.

The two work on their own or together. Qualia can feed any organisational development workflows or methods you already use. Causal Map can read interviews you have gathered any way you like. Used together they form one pipeline, from conversation to evidence, we have shown they work (separately or together) for organisations.

What this surfaces

This is closer to ethnography than to a staff survey. A survey hands people the consultant's categories and asks them to rate each one, so whatever did not make it onto the questionnaire stays invisible. We start from open conversation and let the categories emerge from what people say.

What emerges is each person's mental model of the organisation: what they believe causes what, where they see the levers and the blockages, what they think would actually change things. These models are mostly tacit. People act on them every day, but nobody has written them down, and they often differ sharply between the boardroom and the corridor. Mapping them makes them visible and discussable, in the speakers' own words rather than in anyone's preconceived framework.

The piece we are missing

We are strong on elicitation and analysis. Causal mapping has a long research tradition behind it, and we have plenty of ideas about how to analyse mental models in general.

What we do not have is the organisational development front end, and that splits in two. First, the memorable theory: the named approach with the catchy diagram that a client can hold in their head and repeat to their board. Cynefin has its domains, Lencioni has his pyramid; we have a rigorous method but no story to sell it with. Second, less cynically, the craft of being useful: we do not really know how to write the report, run the workshop or open the process that turns a map into something a real organisation acts on. We are back office. That is the missing link we are looking for in a partner.

What we are open to

We are open to working with a partner who brings the client relationship and a clear point of view on organisations, and who uses our tools as the analytical back end. You advise your clients your way. We give you a rigorous, traceable read of what people in the organisation are telling you.

The kind of partner we have in mind

Ethical and values-driven. The work should serve both the people and the organisation, for example around work life balance, culture or wellbeing, rather than purely squeezing more output from staff.

Small or boutique. Roughly the scale where you are looking for an edge in this space.

At ease with causation or systems. You may already think in terms of feedback, loops, drivers and outcomes, or you map systems. Causal mapping fits most naturally with that language.

Willing to build a method with us. The interesting prospect is co-developing an opinionated, repeatable procedure, your named approach to reading an organisation, built on our tools, rather than buying software

off a shelf. This is the missing piece: you bring the theory and the client craft, we bring the engine.

What a first step could look like

A short conversation to see if there is a fit, then a small joint pilot on one of your live cases, so both sides can judge the value before committing to anything larger.